STUDY AID · MATTHEW 4:12-25 · EPISODE 5 OF 58

Light Dawns *in Galilee*



Where something happens matters as much as what happens.

▶ Watch on YouTube | Read Matthew 4:12-25 in the LSB | 19:31 | Channel: Every Word

Full title: WHY Jesus Went to the Shadow of DEATH (Matthew 4:12-25). Series: The Gospel of Matthew Every Word (playlist of 58 videos).

FROM THE VIDEO | BACKGROUND (ADDED) | DEBATED | LSB TEXT | ◆ LOGOS FACTBOOK LINK

01 · FROM THE VIDEO

Short summary

- The teacher reads Matthew 4:12-25: after John is taken into custody, Jesus leaves Nazareth for Capernaum, by the sea in Zebulun and Naphtali, and Matthew says this fulfills Isaiah 9:1-2. Jesus begins to preach, calls four fishermen, and heals throughout Galilee as crowds gather.
- Matthew skips the early ministry John's Gospel records (the first disciples, water into wine, the temple, Nicodemus, the Samaritan woman). The Gospels are not arranged to line up perfectly, so the teacher reads them side by side.
- Simon and Andrew were not strangers when Jesus called them. Andrew first followed Jesus on John the Baptist's word (John 1:35-42), and they had already seen Him at work. Why they had gone back to fishing, Scripture does not say.
- Geography carries the message. The crowds come from Galilee, Jerusalem and Judea, but also from the Decapolis and beyond the Jordan. For the teacher, that means people from the nations, not only Israel, are already following Jesus.
- 'Fishers of men' would send a Jewish hearer to Jeremiah 16:16, where Yahweh sends fishermen to gather His scattered people.
- The lesson: Jesus began His ministry about as far from Jerusalem as He could, in 'Galilee of the Gentiles,' the land of the shadow of death. There He did two things:

> *"In the Gospel of Matthew, where something happens matters just as much as what happens.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

> *"All types of people, representing the nations, the whole world, is following after Jesus in this initial moment.*
>
> From the video (auto-captions, lightly cleaned)

He preached the gospel to people in darkness, and He healed the suffering. Will we do the same?



Casting a net into the sea (4:18)

James Tissot, The Calling of Saint Peter and Saint Andrew, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain



'Follow Me' (4:19)

Duccio di Buoninsegna, The Calling of the Apostles Peter and Andrew, 1308-1311. National Gallery of Art, Washington, via Wikimedia Commons (CC0)

Read it with a map open

The teacher's opening question is about place: why does Jesus begin in Galilee, and who are all these people coming to hear Him? So read verses 12-25 twice: once for what happens, and once for where it happens. Then ask what the Old Testament says about those places.

The video reads from another English translation. Quotations on this page are from the LSB.

02 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Scripture passages covered

The video reads all of Matthew 4:12-25, then walks through John 1 and 4 to place the scene.
Each link opens those verses on read.lsbible.org.

Matthew 4:12-25
Jesus moves to Capernaum, begins to preach, calls four fishermen and heals throughout Galilee; crowds come from every direction.

Isaiah 9:1-2
The prophecy Matthew quotes: light for Zebulun and Naphtali, 'Galilee of the Gentiles.' Read on to the promised Child in 9:6-7.

John 1:35-42
The video's key background: Andrew and another disciple of John follow Jesus; Andrew brings his brother Simon.

John 4:43-45
The video reads 4:43: after two days in Samaria, Jesus goes on into Galilee.

Mark 1:14-20
Mark's parallel: after John is taken into custody, Jesus preaches in Galilee and calls the same four fishermen.

Luke 4:14-31
Luke's order: Jesus returns to Galilee, is rejected in the Nazareth synagogue, then comes down to Capernaum.

Luke 5:1-11
Luke's fuller call story at the lake, with a great catch of fish. Whether it is the same moment as Matthew 4:18-22 is debated.

Jeremiah 16:14-18
The video's Old Testament key for Jesus' call (Jeremiah 16:16). Read the verses on both sides.

Isaiah 35:5-6
The video links Jesus' healing summary (4:23-24) to this picture of blind eyes opened and the lame leaping.

Matthew 5:1-2
Coming next (Episode 6): seeing the crowds, Jesus goes up on the mountain and teaches.

Key verses in the LSB

“The people who were sitting in darkness saw a great Light, / And those who were sitting in the land and shadow of death, / Upon them a Light dawned.”
Matthew 4:16 (LSB)

“From that time Jesus began to preach and say, “Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.””
Matthew 4:17 (LSB)

“Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men.”
Matthew 4:19 (LSB)

“And large crowds followed Him from Galilee and the Decapolis and Jerusalem and Judea and from beyond the Jordan.”
Matthew 4:25 (LSB)

03 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

Light in the land of shadow

Six moments in verses 12-25, each beside the Old Testament text behind it, both in the LSB.
Video lines are tagged Video; added notes are tagged Background or Debated.



FULFILLED · MATTHEW 4:14-16

A great light for Zebulun and Naphtali

ISAIAH · ISAIAH 9:1-2

“But there will be no more gloom for her who was in anguish; in earlier times He treated the land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali with contempt, but later on He shall make it glorious, by the way of the sea, on the other side of Jordan, Galilee of the Gentiles. / The people who walk in darkness / Will see a great light; / Those who live in the land of the shadow of death, / The light will shine on them.”

MATTHEW · MATTHEW 4:15-16

“The land of Zebulun and the land of Naphtali, / By the way of the sea, beyond the Jordan, Galilee of the Gentiles— / The people who were sitting in darkness saw a great Light, / And those who were sitting in the land and shadow of death, / Upon them a Light dawned.”

FROM THE VIDEO Matthew notes Jesus' return to Galilee and cites Isaiah 9:1-2. The light-and-dark picture fits because Galilee was ringed by pagan nations: 'a veritable land of the shadow of death.'

BACKGROUND Zebulun and Naphtali were the first of Israel's tribes to fall to Assyria: Tiglath-pileser 'took ... Galilee, all the land of Naphtali; and he took them away into exile to Assyria' (2 Kings 15:29). The first to go into the dark are promised the first light. Isaiah goes on to the Child who will be called 'Prince of Peace' (Isaiah 9:6). 2 Kings 15:29 Isaiah 9:6-7

Matthew's wording ('sitting in darkness') is closer to the Greek Old Testament than to the Hebrew ('walk in darkness'). The phrase 'darkness and the shadow of death' returns in Psalm 107:10 and in Zechariah's song about the coming Sunrise (Luke 1:79).

◆ Factbook: Isaiah ◆ Factbook: Tribe of Zebulun ◆ Factbook: Territory of Naphtali ◆ Factbook: Galilee



SAME MESSAGE · MATTHEW 4:17

Repent, the kingdom of heaven is at hand

JOHN THE BAPTIST · MATTHEW 3:2

“Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.”

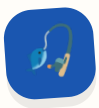
JESUS · MATTHEW 4:17

“Repent, for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.”

FROM THE VIDEO According to Matthew, Jesus begins His ministry after John is taken into custody (4:12), and 'from that time' (4:17) He preaches.

BACKGROUND Word for word, Jesus takes up John's message once John is silenced. Later He sends the Twelve with the same words (Matthew 10:7). 'From that time Jesus began' appears again at 16:21, where Jesus begins to show the disciples that He must suffer: two turning points in Matthew's story. Matthew 10:7 Matthew 16:21

◆ Factbook: John the Baptist ◆ Factbook: Repentance ◆ Factbook: Kingdom of heaven



ECHO · MATTHEW 4:18-20

Fishers of men

JEREMIAH · JEREMIAH 16:16

“Behold, I am going to send for many fishermen,” declares Yahweh, “and they will fish for them; and afterwards I will send for many hunters, and they will hunt them from every mountain and every hill and from the crevices of the rocks.”

JESUS · MATTHEW 4:19

“Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men.”

FROM THE VIDEO A Jew would filter Jesus' words through the Old Testament. In Jeremiah 16, Yahweh sends fishermen to catch the scattered sons of Israel; that is the backdrop the teacher proposes.

DEBATED Jeremiah's fishermen come right after the promise of return (16:14-15), but the next verses speak of judgment: 'I will first doubly repay their iniquity' (Jeremiah 16:18). So some read the fishers as gatherers, others as agents of judgment. Ezekiel gives a hopeful picture: 'fishermen will stand beside it' where the river from the temple brings life (Ezekiel 47:10). Jeremiah 16:14-18

Ezekiel 47:9-10

◆ Factbook: Capernaum



ECHO · MATTHEW 4:21-22

Leaving the nets, the boat and their father

ELISHA AND ELIJAH · 1 KINGS 19:20-21

“So he forsook the oxen and ran after Elijah and said, “Please let me kiss my father and my mother, then I will follow you.” ... Then he arose and followed Elijah and ministered to him.”

JAMES AND JOHN · MATTHEW 4:22

“And immediately they left the boat and their father, and followed Him.”

FROM THE VIDEO The teacher calls this an Elijah-like call to discipleship for Simon, Andrew, James and John.

BACKGROUND Elijah's call of Elisha is the Old Testament's best-known call story: Elisha leaves his oxen and family to follow and serve. Jesus' call is stronger: they leave 'immediately' (4:20, 22), and Jesus Himself, not a prophet's mantle, is the One they follow.

1 Kings 19:19-21

◆ Factbook: Elijah (prophet)



ECHO · MATTHEW 4:23-24

Teaching, preaching, healing

ISAIAH · ISAIAH 35:5-6

“Then the eyes of the blind will be opened, / And the ears of the deaf will be unstopped. / Then the lame will leap like a deer, / And the tongue of the mute will shout for joy.”

MATTHEW · MATTHEW 4:23

“And Jesus was going throughout all Galilee, teaching in their synagogues and preaching the gospel of the kingdom, and healing every kind of disease and every kind of sickness among the people.”

FROM THE VIDEO Healing the sick, the demon-oppressed and the paralyzed (4:24) shows Jesus fulfilling the picture in Isaiah 35.

BACKGROUND Matthew repeats this summary almost word for word at 9:35, framing chapters 5-9: Jesus' teaching (chapters 5-7) and His healing (chapters 8-9). When John asks from prison, Jesus answers in Isaiah's words: 'the blind receive sight and the lame walk' (Matthew 11:5). Matthew 9:35 Matthew 11:4-5

THE CROWDS · MATTHEW 4:24-25

From Galilee, the Decapolis and beyond the Jordan

ISAIAH · ISAIAH 42:6

“I am Yahweh, I have called You in righteousness; / I will also take hold of You by the hand and guard You, / And I will give You as a covenant to the people, / As a light to the nations,”

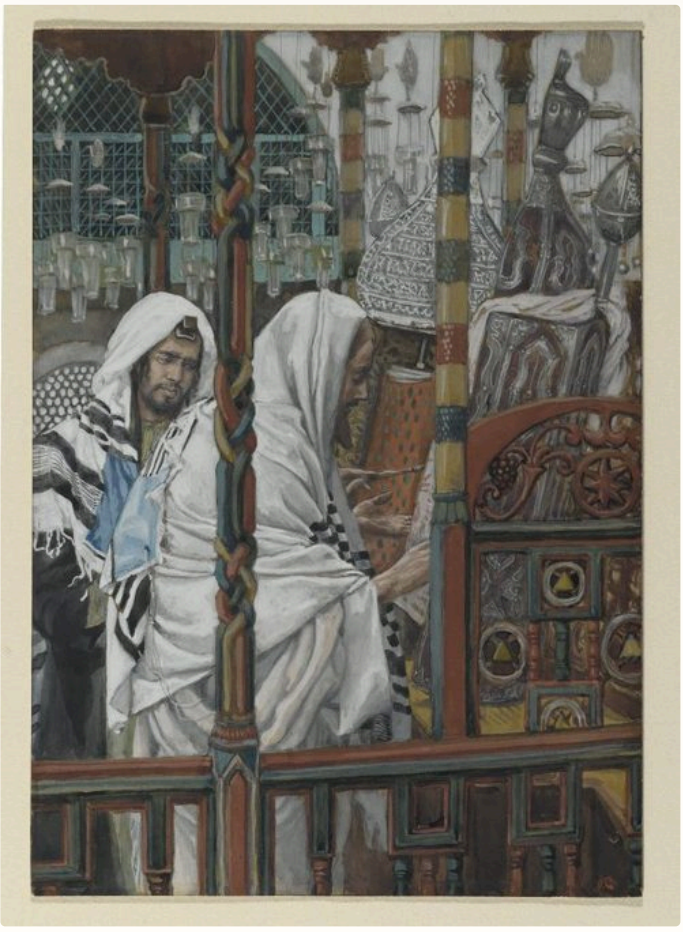
MATTHEW · MATTHEW 4:25

“And large crowds followed Him from Galilee and the Decapolis and Jerusalem and Judea and from beyond the Jordan.”

FROM THE VIDEO The Jordan was a boundary of sorts between Jews and pagans. The Decapolis, 'ten cities,' was largely Gentile and Greek in culture. Matthew is saying the whole world is involved in what Jesus is doing, even though a Jew might expect the Messiah to focus on Israel.

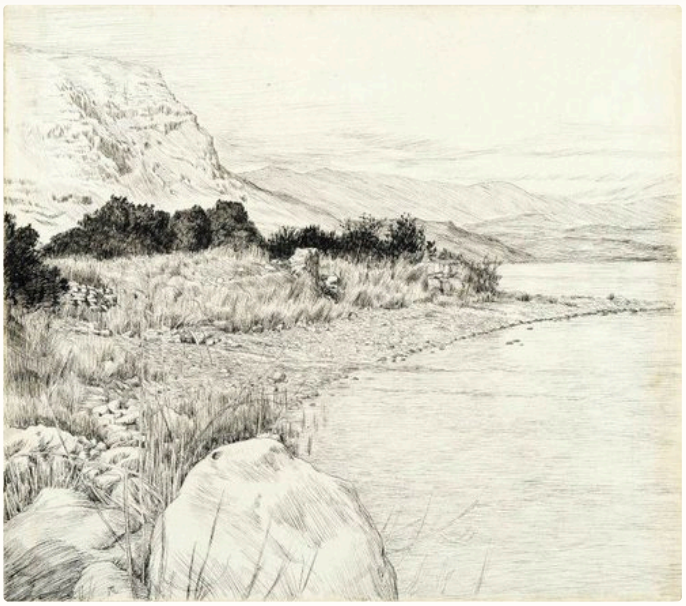
BACKGROUND Isaiah's Servant is 'a light to the nations' (Isaiah 42:6; 49:6). Matthew's Gospel ends where this scene points: 'make disciples of all the nations' (Matthew 28:19). Isaiah 49:6 Matthew 28:18-20

◆ Factbook: Decapolis ◆ Factbook: Jerusalem ◆ Factbook: Jordan River



Teaching in their synagogues (4:23)

James Tissot, Jesus Teaches in the Synagogues, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain



Walking by the Sea of Galilee (4:18)

James Tissot, Sea of Tiberias, 1886-1894. Brooklyn Museum via Wikimedia Commons, public domain

> *“Jesus could have started anywhere, but He chose to go to those in darkness.*

From the video

04 · FROM THE VIDEO · LSB TEXT

They already knew Him

Why did four fishermen drop everything? The teacher reads John's Gospel alongside Matthew. Here is the order he traces.



STEP 1 · JOHN 1

Andrew follows Jesus on John's word

JOHN 1:36-37 (LSB) BEFORE

"and he looked at Jesus as He walked, and said, "Behold, the Lamb of God!" And the two disciples heard him speak and followed Jesus."

FROM THE VIDEO The first disciples of Jesus were actually John's disciples. One was Andrew, who then found his brother Peter (John 1:40-42). John 1:40-42



STEP 2 · JOHN 2-4

They see Him at work

JOHN 2:11 (LSB) BEFORE

"Jesus did this in Cana of Galilee as the beginning of His signs, and manifested His glory, and His disciples believed in Him."

FROM THE VIDEO John's early chapters show the disciples traveling with Jesus: water into wine, the temple in Jerusalem, Nicodemus, and the woman at the well in Samaria (John 2-4). Matthew leaves all of this out.

BACKGROUND John's Gospel is the only one to describe this early Judean and Samaritan ministry.



STEP 3 · JOHN 4; MATTHEW 4:12

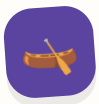
Back to Galilee

JOHN 4:43 (LSB) THEN

"And after the two days He went from there into Galilee."

FROM THE VIDEO This is precisely where Matthew picks it up: 'Now when Jesus heard that John had been taken into custody, He departed into Galilee' (4:12).

BACKGROUND Mark agrees on the timing: 'after John had been delivered up into custody' (Mark 1:14). Luke adds that Jesus taught in Galilee's synagogues, was rejected in Nazareth, and 'came down to Capernaum' (Luke 4:14-31). Mark 1:14 Luke 4:14-31



STEP 4 · MATTHEW 4:18-22

The call by the sea

MATTHEW 4:20 (LSB) THEN

“And immediately they left their nets and followed Him.”

FROM THE VIDEO Read alone, it might seem strange that strangers drop everything. But Simon and Andrew already knew Jesus when He came calling. Why they had gone back to their trade is a question Scripture does not answer.

DEBATED Luke tells a call at the lake with a miraculous catch (Luke 5:1-11). Some read it as the same event told more fully; others as a separate, later moment. Chrysostom calls Matthew's scene 'a second call' after John 1 (see Early witnesses). Luke 5:1-11

> *“The gospel authors are telling a story that requires us to know our Bible, to know our Old Testament, in order to fully appreciate and understand.*
>
> From the video

05

Who's who by the lake

What the video says, then a short background note.

Jesus

VIDEO Begins His public ministry far from Jerusalem, in 'Galilee of the Gentiles,' preaching to people in darkness and healing the suffering.

BACKGROUND Matthew uses the same verb, 'departed' (anachōreō), for the holy family's escape from danger (2:14, 22) and for Jesus' later withdrawals (12:15; 14:13). Jesus does not run from His mission; He moves where Isaiah said the light would shine.

Matthew 2:22-23 Matthew 12:15 Matthew 14:13

◆ Jesus Christ

John the Baptist

VIDEO His arrest marks the start of Jesus' Galilean ministry. Two of his disciples were the first to follow Jesus.

BACKGROUND Herod Antipas 'had John arrested … because of Herodias, the wife of his brother Philip' (Matthew 14:3). Josephus names the fortress of Machaerus, east of the Dead Sea, as the place John was held and killed (Antiquities 18.5.2).

Matthew 14:3-5 John 1:35-37 ◆ John the Baptist

Simon Peter and Andrew

VIDEO Brothers and fishermen. Andrew first heard John point to 'the Lamb of God' and followed Jesus, then brought Simon.

BACKGROUND John says Bethsaida was 'the city of Andrew and Peter' (John 1:44); Peter's house is later in Capernaum (Matthew 8:14). Jesus gives Simon the name Cephas, Peter (John 1:42).

John 1:40-44 Matthew 8:14 Matthew 16:16-17

James and John, sons of Zebedee

VIDEO Called from mending their nets; they leave the boat and their father 'immediately.'

BACKGROUND Mark adds that they left Zebedee 'in the boat with the hired servants' (Mark 1:20), a detail that suggests a family business with employees. With Peter, they later form the inner three (Matthew 17:1).

Mark 1:19-20 Matthew 17:1

◆ James (son of Zebedee) ◆ John (son of Zebedee)

◆ Peter (Simon Peter) ◆ Andrew (apostle) ◆ Fishing

◆ Zebedee ◆ Fishing

Isaiah

VIDEO Foresaw this: light for the people in darkness in Galilee. 'It's not as if this is something novel.'

BACKGROUND Isaiah prophesied in Judah in the 8th century BC, as Assyria swallowed the northern tribes. His promise of light (9:1-2) leads straight into the royal Child of 9:6-7.

Isaiah 9:1-7 ◆ Isaiah

The crowds

VIDEO From Galilee, the Decapolis, Jerusalem, Judea and beyond the Jordan: representatives of the nations, not only Israel.

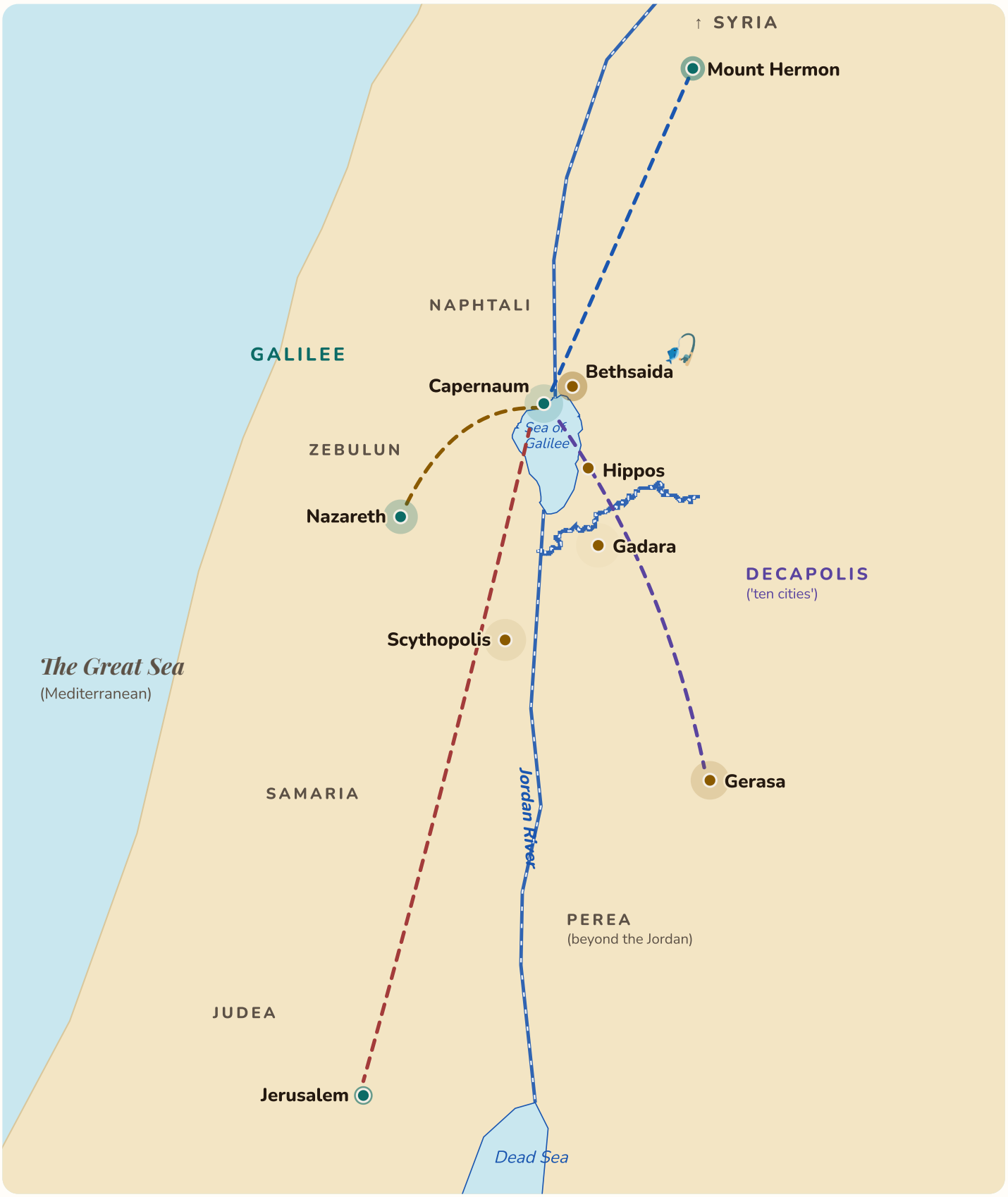
BACKGROUND 'All Syria' (4:24) was the Roman province to the north. Matthew's list maps the four directions of the land around Galilee. The crowds are the ones Jesus sees before He goes up the mountain to teach (5:1).

Matthew 4:24-25 Matthew 5:1 ◆ Galilee ◆ Decapolis

06 · BACKGROUND

Galilee of the Gentiles

Teal pins are places the video names; gold pins are background. The crowds of 4:25 come from every side of the lake. Routes are schematic.



Named in the video · Background · Leaving Nazareth for Capernaum (4:13) · Crowds from Jerusalem and Judea (4:25)

Crowds from the Decapolis and beyond the Jordan (4:25) · News spreads through all Syria (4:24)

Positions of cities from their known sites; tribal areas, regions and routes are approximate and schematic. Coastline, Dead Sea and most rivers: Natural Earth (public domain). Sea of Galilee outline and the Yarmuk River: OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).

Capernaum VIDEO

'By the sea, in the region of Zebulun and Naphtali' (4:13). Jesus' new home; Peter's house (8:14).

◆ Factbook: Capernaum

Nazareth VIDEO

Jesus' hometown, which He leaves (4:13).

◆ Factbook: Nazareth

Bethsaida BACKGROUND

'The city of Andrew and Peter' (John 1:44).

◆ Factbook: Bethsaida

Mount Hermon VIDEO

The video's map: below it rise the sources of the Jordan, which flows into the Sea of Galilee.

◆ Factbook: Mount Hermon

Jerusalem VIDEO

Crowds come even from Jerusalem and Judea (4:25).

◆ Factbook: Jerusalem

Hippos BACKGROUND

A Decapolis city on a hill across the lake from Capernaum.

◆ Factbook: Decapolis ◆ Factbook: Hippos

Gadara BACKGROUND

A Decapolis city above the Yarmuk valley.

◆ Factbook: Decapolis ◆ Factbook: Gadara

Scythopolis BACKGROUND

Old Beth-shean: the one Decapolis city west of the Jordan.

◆ Factbook: Decapolis

◆ Factbook: Beth-shan (Scythopolis)

Gerasa BACKGROUND

A large Decapolis city east of the Jordan (modern Jerash).

◆ Factbook: Decapolis ◆ Factbook: Gerasa

07

Key terms

Taken into custody

BACKGROUND

Literally 'handed over' (paradidōmi). Matthew uses the same verb when Jesus Himself will be 'delivered' (17:22; 26:2). John's fate foreshadows Jesus'.

◆ Factbook: John the Baptist

Galilee of the Gentiles

VIDEO

Isaiah's name for the northern region (Isaiah 9:1), ringed by non-Israelite peoples and the first part of Israel taken by Assyria (2 Kings 15:29). In Jesus' day Galilee's villages were largely Jewish, with Gentile cities all around.

◆ Factbook: Galilee ◆ Factbook: Gentiles

The way of the sea

Shadow of death

BACKGROUND

Isaiah 9:1, quoted in 4:15. Often linked to the coastal trade route later called the Via Maris, or to the road by the Sea of Galilee. Which one Isaiah meant is debated.

◆ Factbook: Via Maris

VIDEO

The video's title phrase. Darkness that feels like death: Psalm 23:4 uses the same Hebrew word for 'the valley of the shadow of death.' Zechariah sings of the Sunrise who will 'shine upon those who sit in darkness and the shadow of death' (Luke 1:79).

Repent

BACKGROUND

A change of mind that turns a person around. John (3:2) and Jesus (4:17) preach the same words.

◆ Factbook: Repentance

Kingdom of heaven

BACKGROUND

Matthew's usual phrase where Mark and Luke say 'kingdom of God' (compare Mark 1:15). God's rule breaking in through Jesus; 'at hand' means it has drawn near.

◆ Factbook: Kingdom of heaven

Fishers of men

VIDEO

Jesus turns the brothers' trade into a picture of their mission. The video reads it against Jeremiah 16:16.

◆ Factbook: Fishing

Decapolis

VIDEO

'Ten cities': a league of Greek cities, mostly east of the Jordan (Pliny the Elder lists ten, Natural History 5.16.74). The video: largely Gentile and heavily influenced by Greek culture and religion.

◆ Factbook: Decapolis

Beyond the Jordan

BACKGROUND

The land east of the Jordan; in Jesus' day, Perea, ruled like Galilee by Herod Antipas.

◆ Factbook: Jordan River ◆ Factbook: Perea

08 · BACKGROUND

Hebrew and Greek words

Strong's numbers match the LSB's own word tagging for the verses listed. Glosses summarize the standard lexicons; 'Look up' points you to the entry to read for yourself (BDAG for Greek; BDB or HALOT for Hebrew).

ἀναχωρέω

anachōreō G402

παραδίδωμι

paradidōmi G3860

To withdraw, go away, often from danger. Used for the escape to Egypt (2:14), the move to Galilee (2:22) and here (4:12). Look up: BDAG, ἀναχωρέω.

Greek · Matt 4:12; 2:14, 22

◆ Factbook: Galilee

To hand over, deliver up; used of arrest. LSB: 'taken into custody' (4:12). Later of Jesus being 'delivered' (17:22).

Greek · Matt 4:12

◆ Factbook: John the Baptist

σκιά

skia G4639

Shadow. With thanatos (death, G2288): 'shadow of death,' as in the Greek Old Testament of Isaiah 9:2.

Greek · Matt 4:16

ἀνατέλλω

anatellō G393

To rise, spring up, dawn (of the sun). Related to anatolē, the 'east' or 'rising' where the magi saw the star (2:2).

Greek · Matt 4:16

κηρύσσω

kēryssō G2784

To proclaim as a herald (kēryx). Used of John (3:1) and now of Jesus.

Greek · Matt 4:17, 23

μετανοέω

metanoeō G3340

To change one's mind, repent; in the Gospels, a turning of the whole life toward God. Look up: BDAG, μετανοέω.

Greek · Matt 4:17; 3:2

◆ Factbook: Repentance

ἐγγίζω

engizō G1448

To come near, approach. The perfect ēngiken, 'has come near,' is rendered 'is at hand.'

Greek · Matt 4:17; 3:2

◆ Factbook: Kingdom of heaven

ἁλιεύς

halieus G231

Fisherman. Jesus keeps the word and changes the catch: 'fishers of men.'

Greek · Matt 4:18, 19

◆ Factbook: Fishing

εὐαγγέλιον

euangelion G2098

Good news. Also used in the Roman world for imperial announcements, for example the Priene calendar inscription (9 BC) on Augustus' birthday. Look up: BDAG, εὐαγγέλιον.

Greek · Matt 4:23

◆ Factbook: Gospel

θεραπεύω

therapeuō G2323

To serve, care for; to heal (our 'therapy').

Greek · Matt 4:23, 24

◆ Factbook: Healing

Δεκάπολις

צַלְמָוֶת

Dekapolis `G1179`

'Ten cities' (deka + polis), the Greek city league east of Galilee.

Greek · Matt 4:25

◆ Factbook: Decapolis

tsalmaveth `H6757`

Traditionally read as tsel, 'shadow,' plus maveth, 'death'; many lexicons explain it as 'deep darkness.' The same word as Psalm 23:4. Look up: BDB or HALOT, צַלְמָוֶת.

Hebrew · Isa 9:2

גָּלִיל

galil `H1551`

Circle, district: the source of the name Galilee. Isaiah's 'Galilee of the Gentiles' is literally 'the district of the nations.'

Hebrew · Isa 9:1

◆ Factbook: Galilee

גּוֹי

goy `H1471`

Nation, people; plural goyim, 'the nations,' the Gentiles.

Hebrew · Isa 9:1

◆ Factbook: Gentiles

נָגַהּ

nagah `H5050`

To shine, give light: 'The light will shine on them.'

Hebrew · Isa 9:2

דַּיָּג

dayyag `H1728`

Fisherman. Used in Jeremiah 16:16 and in Ezekiel's river of life (47:10).

Hebrew · Jer 16:16; Ezek 47:10

◆ Factbook: Fishing

09

Historical and cultural background

ESTABLISHED **Facts most interpreters agree on**

Galilee in Jesus' day

A fertile region of farming villages and fishing towns around the lake, ruled by Herod Antipas (4 BC-AD 39). Archaeology suggests its villages were largely Jewish, surrounded by Gentile neighbors: Phoenician Tyre and Sidon to the northwest, the Decapolis to the east.

Capernaum

A fishing village on the northwest shore. Visitors today see a white limestone synagogue from late antiquity, built on top of an earlier basalt foundation, and an octagonal church over a house many identify as Peter's (Matthew 8:14).

Fishing on the lake

Simon and Andrew were 'casting a net' (4:18), a circular throw-net; James and John were 'mending their nets' (4:21) in a boat with hired servants (Mark

John in prison

Herod Antipas arrested John for condemning his marriage to Herodias (Matthew 14:3-4). Josephus says Herod feared John's influence over the crowds

1:20). A first-century fishing boat, about 8 m long, was found in the mud near Ginosar in 1986.

and that John was held at the fortress of Machaerus (Antiquities 18.5.2).

Isaiah 9 in history

In 733/732 BC Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria took 'Galilee, all the land of Naphtali' and deported its people (2 Kings 15:29). Isaiah promised that the same land, first humbled, would be the first to see the light.

SOURCED Early witnesses

> *by darkness here not meaning that which is sensible, but men's errors and ungodliness.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 14, on Matthew 4:16, Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, series 1, vol. 10 (public domain). On the move itself he says Jesus withdrew 'to soothe the envy of the Jews' and to teach us 'not to go to meet temptations.'

> *And yet John says that they were called in another manner. Whence it is evident that this was a second call; and from many things one may perceive this.*
>
> John Chrysostom, c. AD 390. Homilies on Matthew 14, on Matthew 4:18-19 (same source). He notes that in John 1 Andrew calls Peter, 'but here Jesus calls both.'

DEBATED Where scholars differ

One call or several?

John 1 has Andrew and Simon meeting Jesus in Judea; Matthew and Mark have a call by the lake; Luke 5 adds a miraculous catch. Many, like Chrysostom and the video, see stages: first meeting, then a call to leave their work. Others think Luke 5 and Matthew 4 tell the same moment.

What does 'fishers of men' echo?

Jeremiah 16:16 is the video's key. Because the next verses speak of judgment, some read Jeremiah's fishermen as hauling Israel to account, not gathering them home. Others point to the hopeful fishermen of Ezekiel 47:10, or think Jesus simply plays on their trade.

Why did Jesus go to Galilee?

Matthew's answer is Scripture: to fulfill Isaiah 9. The video adds that Jesus chose to go to those in darkness. Chrysostom stresses prudence: Jesus withdrew from danger after John's arrest. The answers can stand together.

Where was 'the way of the sea'?

The coastal road by the Mediterranean, a road by the Sea of Galilee, or a general phrase for the western district. Matthew's point does not depend on the answer: Jesus' new home 'by the sea' (4:13) puts Him on that road.

CAREFUL READING

Small slips in the video

Small slips worth knowing (offered gently; the video's main points stand):

- The video says Jesus headed back to Galilee 'after the rejection by his own hometown community in Nazareth.' Luke places the Nazareth synagogue scene after Jesus has already returned to Galilee (Luke 4:14-30). John 4:44 says only that 'a prophet has no honor in his own country.'
- The video treats the east side of the Jordan as where 'the pagans lived.' The Decapolis was largely Gentile, but 'beyond the Jordan' (Perea) was mostly Jewish and ruled, like Galilee, by Herod Antipas. And one Decapolis city, Scythopolis, lay west of the Jordan. The point that Gentiles came to hear Jesus still stands.
- Matthew does not quote Isaiah 35 in this passage; the healing summary echoes it. Jesus makes the link Himself later, in Isaiah's words: 'the blind receive sight and the lame walk' (Matthew 11:5).
- On Jeremiah 16:16, the video says the fishermen catch 'the scattered sons of Israel.' Verse 15 does promise return, but verses 17-18 speak of judgment, so the verse is read both ways (see Where scholars differ).
- The captions read 'Matthew 4: 12 to2'; the passage is Matthew 4:12-25.

10 · BACKGROUND

From Assyria's shadow to the dawn

Coral dots mark what Matthew 4:12-25 quotes, echoes or tells. Early dates are approximate; dates tagged debated vary among scholars.

C. 740-700 BC
Isaiah prophesies light for Zebulun and Naphtali
Isaiah 9:1-2 *Quoted: 4:15-16*

733/732 BC
Tiglath-pileser III takes Galilee and Naphtali into exile
2 Kings 15:29 *The darkness*

C. 600 BC
Jeremiah: 'I am going to send for many fishermen'
Jeremiah 16:16 *Echo: 4:19*

4 BC-AD 39
Herod Antipas rules Galilee and Perea
Matthew 14:1-5

C. AD 27-29 DEBATED
After the baptism and testing, Andrew and Simon first meet Jesus
John 1:35-42

SOON AFTER DEBATED
John is taken into custody; Jesus moves to Capernaum and begins to preach
Matthew 4:12-17 *This episode*

SOON AFTER
Four fishermen called by the Sea of Galilee
Matthew 4:18-22 *This episode*

LATER

The Twelve are sent: 'The kingdom of heaven is at hand'

Matthew 10:5-7

AD 30 OR 33 DEBATED

The risen Jesus: 'make disciples of all the nations'

Matthew 28:18-20

11

Cross-references

Added cross-references for further study.

Mark 1:14-20; Luke 4:14-15
Parallel accounts of the start in Galilee
ADDED

John 1:35-42
Andrew and Simon first meet Jesus
ADDED

Luke 5:1-11
The great catch and the call to catch men
ADDED

Isaiah 9:1-7
Light in Galilee and the Child who rules on David's throne
ADDED

Isaiah 42:6-7; 49:6
The Servant as 'a light to the nations'
ADDED

Psalm 107:10-14
Brought out of darkness and the shadow of death
ADDED

Luke 1:78-79
The Sunrise from on high shines on those in darkness
ADDED

John 8:12
'I am the Light of the world'
ADDED

Jeremiah 16:14-18; Ezekiel 47:9-10
Two Old Testament pictures of fishermen
ADDED

1 Kings 19:19-21
Elisha leaves his oxen to follow Elijah
ADDED

Matthew 9:35-38
The same summary of teaching, preaching and healing, and compassion for the crowds
ADDED

Matthew 28:18-20
From 'Galilee of the Gentiles' to 'all the nations'
ADDED

12

Reflection and discussion

0 of 5 questions marked done on this device.

1. [ ] The video asks: why didn't Jesus begin in Jerusalem? What do you think, and what does Isaiah 9:1-2 add?

2. [ ] Simon and Andrew already knew Jesus (John 1:35-42) before He called them to leave their nets. What had to happen before they could leave 'immediately'? What is Jesus asking you to leave?

3. [ ] The video's challenge: 'Are you willing to go to the dark places, to the shadow of death?' Name one 'dark place' near you where the gospel and practical care are both needed.

4. [ ] The crowds came from every direction, including Gentile cities. Who are the 'Decapolis' people in your circles that you might not expect to follow Jesus?

5. [ ] Read Jeremiah 16:14-18 and Ezekiel 47:9-10. Which picture of fishermen helps you most to understand 'fishers of men'?

Application

FROM THE VIDEO

Jesus did two things in the land of the shadow of death: He taught and preached the gospel to those dwelling in darkness, and He healed the suffering. The lesson for the original audience: God's people go to dark places, share the gospel, and do what they can to heal. The lesson for you: are you willing to do the same? Not necessarily working miracles, but healing a broken spirit or a broken heart, people hurting from church hurt, past trauma, emotional turmoil and spiritual pain, by giving the gospel and showing the love of Christ.

STUDY NOTE (ADDED)

Jesus' first followers did not start as experts; they started by following: 'Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men' (4:19). The making is His work. When the crowds later look like 'sheep without a shepherd,' Jesus tells the disciples first to 'pray earnestly to the Lord of the harvest' (Matthew 9:36-38). Start there: pray for the people in your own Galilee, then go.

> *"Are you willing to go to the dark places, to the shadow of death, and teach and preach the gospel, while at the same time healing those who are suffering?*
>
> From the video

Look it up in Logos

Each link opens that person, place or topic in the Logos Factbook, inside the Logos app on iPad, Mac or PC. The same links are in Copy all notes.

◆ Jesus Christ ◆ John the Baptist ◆ Isaiah ◆ Elijah (prophet) ◆ Galilee ◆ Capernaum ◆ Nazareth ◆ Tribe of Zebulun ◆ Territory of Naphtali ◆ Decapolis ◆ Jerusalem ◆ Jordan River ◆ Repentance ◆ Kingdom of heaven ◆ John Chrysostom ◆ Andrew (apostle) ◆ Bethsaida ◆ Demon possession ◆ Disciples ◆ Elisha ◆ Ezekiel (prophet) ◆ Fishing ◆ Gadara ◆ Gentiles ◆ Gerasa ◆ Gospel ◆ Healing ◆ Herod Antipas ◆ Hippos ◆ James (son of Zebedee) ◆ Jeremiah (prophet) ◆ John (son of Zebedee) ◆ Judea ◆ Machaerus ◆ Mount Hermon ◆ Nicodemus ◆ Perea ◆ Prayer ◆ Beth-shan (Scythopolis) ◆ Sea of Galilee ◆ Sermon on the Mount ◆ Peter (Simon Peter) ◆ Synagogue ◆ Syria ◆ Tiberias ◆ Tiglath-pileser III ◆ The Twelve ◆ Via Maris ◆ Zebedee

Source: the video's auto-generated YouTube captions, read in full. Scripture quotations are from the Legacy Standard Bible, copyright 2021 by The Lockman Foundation. All rights reserved. Chrysostom: Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers (public domain). Images: Wikimedia Commons (James Tissot, Brooklyn Museum, public domain; Duccio, National Gallery of Art, CC0). Map data: Natural Earth (public domain) and OpenStreetMap contributors (ODbL).

Offline copy. Live page: https://shea-nelson.github.io/workout-app/bible/matthew-5/